



**Passage Analysis of William Hazlitt, “On Familiar Style”
from *Table Talk: Essays on Men and Manners*
AP[®] Language Multiple Choice Lesson**

Read the passage below and answer the guided questions before going on to the multiple choice questions.

It is not easy to write in a familiar style. Many people mistake a familiar for a vulgar style, and suppose that to write without affectation is to write at random. On the contrary, there is nothing
5 that requires more precision, and, if I may so say, purity of expression, than the style I am speaking of. It utterly rejects not only all unmeaning pomp, but allow, cant phrases, and loose, unconnected, slipshod allusions. It is not to take the first word
10 that offers, but the best word in common use; it is not to throw words together in any combination we please, but to follow and avail ourselves of the true idiom of the language. To write a genuine familiar or truly English style, is to write as any one would
15 speak in common conversation, who had a thorough command and choice of words, or who could discourse with ease, force, and perspicuity, setting aside all pedantic and oratorical flourishes. Or to give another illustration, to write naturally is the
20 same thing in regard to common conversation, as to read naturally is in regard to common speech. It does not follow that it is an easy thing to give the true accent and inflection to the words you utter, because you do not attempt to rise above the level
25 of ordinary life and colloquial speaking. You do not assume indeed the solemnity of the pulpit, or the tone of stage-declamation: neither are you at liberty to gabble on at a venture, without emphasis or discretion, or to resort to vulgar dialect or clownish
30 pronunciation. You must steer a middle course. You are tied down to a given and appropriate articulation, which is determined by the habitual associations between sense and sound, and which you can only hit by entering into the author's
35 meaning, as you must find the proper words and

1. Paraphrase the error people commit. (2nd sen.)
2. Underline the words that signal Hazlitt is now going to state his claim.
3. What is “it” referring to (line 7)?
4. What does Hazlitt mean by “offers” (line 10)?
5. Notice how Hazlitt organizes this sentence. (beginning with “It is not” line 9).
6. Hazlitt draws a parallel between writing and _____.
7. Explain the analogy here (lines 18-21)
_____ is to _____ as
to _____ is to _____.
8. To what logical error is Hazlitt referring here (line 21-23)?
9. Underline the words in this sentence and the next which have to do with talking (beginning in line 21 with “It does not follow”).
10. What does Hazlitt mean by “get upon stilts”(line 39)?

style to express your self by fixing your thoughts on the subject you have to write about. Any one may mouth out a passage with a theatrical cadence, or get upon stilts to tell his thoughts: but to write or

40 speak with propriety and simplicity is a more difficult task. Thus it is easy to affect a pompous style, to use a word twice as big as the thing you want to express: it is not so easy to pitch upon the very word that exactly fits it. Out of eight or ten

45 words equally common, equally intelligible, with nearly equal pretensions, it is a matter of some nicety and discrimination to pick out the very one, the preferableness of which is scarcely perceptible, but decisive. The reason why I object to Dr.

50 Johnson's style is, that there is no discrimination, no selection, no variety in it. He uses none but "tall, opaque words," taken from the "first row of the rubric:"—words with the greatest number of syllables, or Latin phrases with merely English

55 terminations. If a fine style depended on this sort of arbitrary pretension, it would be fair to judge of an author's elegance by the measurement of his words, and the substitution of foreign circumlocutions (with no precise associations) for the mother-

60 tongue. How simple it is to be dignified without ease, to be pompous without meaning! Surely, it is but a mechanical rule for avoiding what is low to be always pedantic and affected. It is clear you cannot use a vulgar English word, if you never use a

65 common English word at all. A fine tact is shown in adhering to those which are perfectly common, and yet never falling into any expressions which are debased by disgusting circumstances, or which owe their signification and point to technical or

70 professional allusions. A truly natural or familiar style can never be quaint or vulgar, for this reason, that it is of universal force and applicability, and that quaintness and vulgarity arise out of the immediate connection of certain words with coarse

75 and disagreeable, or with confined ideas. (1821)

11. What does Hazlitt mean by "pitch upon" (line 43)?

12. Paraphrase what Hazlitt is saying in the sentence beginning with line 44 "Out of eight."

13. What, according to Hazlitt, is wrong with the way Dr. Johnson writes?

14. Here Hazlitt returns to his main idea (line 56 "How simple"). Paraphrase what he means in this sentence.

15. What is "those" referring to (line 66)?

16. Notice Hazlitt's use of parallelism in the last sentence. Underline the parallel elements.